

Title

Accessibility and effectiveness of hepatitis C treatment integrated at harm-reduction facilities: protocol for a randomized trial in people who inject drugs

Abstract

People who inject drugs (PWID) experience disproportionate hepatitis C burden but encounter substantial barriers to accessing curative treatment, including fragmented healthcare systems, geographic distance, and stigma. This protocol describes a randomized trial evaluating an accessible care model wherein hepatitis C screening, treatment initiation, and clinical support are delivered directly on-site at harm-reduction facilities, compared with standard referral-based pathways. An estimated 165 HCV RNA-positive PWID reporting injection drug use within the prior 90 days will be randomized 1:1 to accessible on-site care or standard referral. Primary outcome measures assess treatment-related changes in injection frequency, injection-related risk behaviors, and uptake of opioid-use-disorder treatment during 12 months of follow-up. Secondary outcomes examine hepatitis C treatment initiation and completion rates. This pragmatic design tests whether eliminating geographic, administrative, and stigma-related barriers to hepatitis C care influences both health-related behaviors and disease treatment engagement in an underserved population.